



Battle of Pleasant Hill

Readers of the May 14, 1864 edition of Frank Leslie's *Illustrated Newspaper* could study this depiction of General Nathaniel Banks's repulse of Confederate forces during his ill-starred Red River expedition.

The "Wizard of the Saddle"

In Mississippi, meanwhile, the Union's woes could be summed up in three words: Nathan Bedford Forrest. The fearsome Confederate cavalryman—nicknamed the "Wizard of the Saddle"—had for years been wreaking havoc in Union-held Kentucky and Tennessee. He also triggered outrage across the North when, on April 12, 1864, while sacking Fort Pillow to the north of Memphis, he appeared to condone the massacre of many of its Black soldiers.

As spring turned to summer, the Confederate forces in Mississippi, guarding the western approaches to the South's vital Selma Arsenal in Alabama, were increasingly needed in the campaign against Sherman, who had begun to move on Atlanta. Forrest spurred northward to raid Sherman's long supply line, which snaked back through the hills of Tennessee. Sherman dispatched General Samuel Sturgis from Union-held Memphis to stop Forrest.

With only 4,800 troopers in his command, Forrest lured Sturgis and his 8,500 men ever deeper down the rutted Mississippi lanes.